

Telugu, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Telugu one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Telugu letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read నమస్కారం *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Telugu simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Telugu — famous as “the Italian of the East” for its open, vowel-final music — is one of the four literary **Dravidian** languages, a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit. Like its sister Kannada, and unlike Tamil, it borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit; so “hello” is the Sanskrit నమస్కారం (*namaskāram*), yet “yes” and “okay” are the native అవును (*avunu*) and సరే (*sarē*). Telugu also shows the family is no monolith: where its sisters say “no” with a word from the root *il-*, Telugu goes its own way with లేదు (*lēdu*). Each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Telugu out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Telugu greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Telugu script and how Telugu sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/TE-C01-*.md.*

1.1 నమస్కారం (*namaskāram*) — “greetings”

The letters in this word

Telugu reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a” (many under a little check-mark hat, the *talakattu*). న na, మ ma, ర ra. A **vowel sign** changes it: క ka + long-ā → కా kā. A vowel-less consonant **stacks below** the next as a conjunct: స tucks under ka → స్క “ska.” And the **anusvāra** ం adds a final nasal “-m̐.” Read న·మ·స్·కా·ర·ం → *namaskāram*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నమస్కారం (*namaskāram*) is **Sanskrit**: *namas* (“a bow, homage”) + *kāra* (“a making,” root *kr*, “to do”), with a Telugu ending = “the making of a bow.” The same word as Hindi *namaskār* and Kannada *namaskāra*. Telugu borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit — often called the most Sanskritised Dravidian tongue — where its sister Tamil kept the home-grown *vaṇakkam*.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Hello”	Source
Telugu	నమస్కారం <i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
Tamil	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Tamil alone kept its own word.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. Both **hello** and **goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone.

1.2 ధన్యవాదములు — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ధ *dha* (aspirated *d*), the conjunct న్న (*na* stacked with *ya*), then వా·ద·ము·లు. Read ధ·న్య·వా·ద·ము·లు → *dhanyavādamulu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The core is **Sanskrit**: *dhanya* (“worthy,” from *dhana*, “wealth”) + *vāda* (“a saying,” root *vad*). Telugu adds its own **plural ending -mulu**, so *dhanyavāda-mulu* = “worthy-sayings,” thanks in the plural of courtesy (also the shorter *dhanyavādālu*). Same Sanskrit stem as Hindi *dhanyavād*.

Grammar Lens

Telugu builds words by gluing endings on. *-mulu* is your first taste of Dravidian *agglutination*: meaning is stacked by suffixes on a stem, not by separate little words. Later endings mark case (“to,” “from,” “with”) the same way. In Telugu, grammar is mostly **suffixes**.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Telugu	ధన్యవాదములు <i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit stem + Telugu plural
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit — same stem
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād</i>	Sanskrit — same stem
Tamil	<i>nanṛi</i>	native (“goodness”)
Malayalam	<i>nandi</i>	native

1.3 అవును (*avunu*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

అ is the **independent vowel** “a” (word-initial). వు is *vu*, ను is *nu* (each a consonant with the “u” sign). Read అ·వు·ను → *avunu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

అవును (*avunu*) is the everyday native “yes / it is so” — close at root to the verb of being, which is why its “no” partner *kādu* (“is not”) is its exact mirror.

Grammar Lens

Telugu’s yes/no are little **statements of being**: *avunu* (“it is [so]”) vs. *kādu* (“it is not”). A Dravidian instinct — answer by asserting or denying existence, not with a bare particle. You’ll also hear a “yes” echoed as the question’s own verb.

1.4 లేదు (*lēdu*) — “no,” where Telugu parts ways with its sisters

The letters in this word

లే is *lē* (ల *la* with the long-“ē” sign); దు is *du*. Read లే·దు → *lēdu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

లేదు (*lēdu*) means “there is not, it is absent” — native Dravidian, but on a **different root** (*lē-*) from the *il-* of Tamil and Kannada. Telugu also has కాదు (*kādu*), “it is not [that],” so it splits “no” in two: *lēdu* denies **existence** (*pustakam lēdu*, “there is no book”); *kādu* denies **identity** (*idi pustakam kādu*, “this is not a book”).

Grammar Lens

Two “no”s, existence vs. identity. English leans on one flat “no”; Telugu keeps *lēdu* (“there isn’t”) and *kādu* (“isn’t that”). Choosing between them is choosing *what* you deny — a Dravidian trait Telugu draws most sharply, and with a different root-word from its sisters.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“No / isn’t”	Note
Telugu	లేదు / కాదు <i>lēdu</i> / <i>kādu</i>	native, different root
Tamil	<i>illai</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Kannada	<i>illa</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Malayalam	<i>illa</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Hindi	<i>nahīm</i>	Indo-European (unrelated)

Three sisters share *il-*; Telugu alone picked *lē-* / *kā-* — the family is real, but not uniform.

1.5 సరి (*sarē*) — “okay,” the family word in Telugu dress

The letters in this word

స is *sa*; రి is *rē* (ర *ra* with the long-“ē” sign you just met on *lē*). Read స·రి → *sarē*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

సరి (*sarē*) is native Dravidian “correct, right” → “okay, agreed” — the verbal nod of Telugu. It is the same family word as Tamil and Kannada

sari, worn to *sarē*; doubled, *sarē sarē* = “alright, alright.”

Grammar Lens

One Dravidian word, three scripts. *sari* / *sarē* is essentially one word and meaning dressed in Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu letters. Spotting a shared word change its shape but not its sense is the fastest way to feel the family — and the whole point of learning these four side by side.

1.6 Recap, and how Telugu says goodbye

Read		Meaning	Origin
నమస్కారం	<i>namaskāram</i>	hello	Sanskrit
ధన్యవాదములు	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	thank you	Sanskrit + Telugu plural
అవును	<i>avunu</i>	yes	native
లేదు	<i>lēdu</i>	no / isn’t	native (root <i>lē-</i> , not <i>il-</i>)
సరే	<i>sarē</i>	okay	native (= <i>sari</i>)

The familiar pattern — Sanskrit for the greetings, native for the everyday grammar — with Telugu’s own twist: its “no” takes a different native root from its sisters.

Why it’s said this way

The same “go and come back.” Telugu, too, avoids a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is వెళ్ళి వస్తాను (*velli vastānu*), “having gone, I [will] come [back],” with the reply వెళ్ళి రండి (*veli raṇḍi*), “go, and come back” — the worldview you met in Tamil’s *pōy varugirēn* and Kannada’s *hōgi baruttēne*.

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *nā pēru...* (“my name...”) — and Telugu’s *nuvvu* / *mīru* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

నా పేరు అరుణ్. (nā pēru Arun — “My name is Arun.”)
మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? (mī pēru ēmiṭi — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/TE-C02-*.md.*

2.1 పేరు (pēru) — “name,” the native Dravidian word

The letters in this word

ప (pa) + ే (the ē-sign) → పే (pē); రు (ru). Read పే·రు → pēru.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పేరు (pēru, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian *pēr — the *same* word as Tamil *peyar* and Malayalam *pēr*, and a cousin of Kannada *hesaru* (which softened the old *p* to *h*). It is *not* the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*). Even in Telugu — the most Sanskritised of the Dravidian tongues — the everyday word for “name” stayed home-grown.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Name”	Source
Telugu	పేరు <i>pēru</i>	native Dravidian (*pēr)
Tamil	<i>peyar</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Malayalam	<i>pēr</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Kannada	<i>hesaru</i>	Dravidian (*pesar, p→h)
Hindi	<i>nām</i>	Sanskrit (Indo-European)
English	<i>name</i>	Indo-European

2.2 నా (*nā*) — “my”

The letters in this word

న (*na*) + ా (long ā) → నా (*nā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నా (*nā*, “my”) is the possessive of నేను (*nēnu*, “I”) — native Dravidian, on the pronoun stem *nān/*yān behind Tamil *nān* and Kannada *nānu*. No Indo-European cousin: the Dravidian “I/my” is a wholly different word from the European *I/my*.

2.3 నా పేరు ... (*nā pēru ...*) — “my name is...”

నా (my) + పేరు (name) + name = **nā pēru ...** *Nā pēru Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

No word for “is.” As in Tamil and Kannada, there is *no* verb: Telugu sets “my name” beside “Arun” and lets the “is” be understood — the **zero copula** of the Dravidian family. *Nā pēru Arun* = literally “my name Arun.”

2.4 నువ్వు / మీరు (*nuvvu* / *mīru*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

నువ్వు (*nuvvu*); మీరు (*mīru*, మీ *mī* + రు *ru*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నువ్వు (*nuvvu*, familiar “you”) traces to Proto-Dravidian *nīn — the same native root as Tamil *nī* and Kannada *nīnu*. మీరు (*mīru*) is the respectful/plural “you.”

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural, again. *nuvvu* (familiar) vs. *mīru* (respectful, and literally plural) — the same politeness-by-plural as Tamil *nīṅgaḷ*, Kannada *nīvu*, and French *vous*. For a first meeting, *mīru*.

2.5 ఏమిటి (*ēmiṭi*) — “what”

The letters in this word

ఏ (independent long ē) + మి (*mi*) + టి (*ṭi*, retroflex) → *ēmiṭi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఏమిటి (*ēmiṭi*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem *yā-/*e- — the same Dravidian question-root as Tamil *eṇṇa* and Kannada *ēnu*, heading Telugu’s question family: *ēmiṭi* (what), *evaru* (who), *ekkaḍa* (where), *enduku* (why).

2.6 మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? (*mī pēru ēmiṭi*) — “what’s your name?”

మీ (*mī*, “your”) is the possessive of *mīru* (“you,” respectful). So మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? is literally “**your name what?**” — and again *no* “*is*.” Three words, no verb.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *Nā pēru Arun*. The familiar “your” is *nī* (from *nuvvu*): *nī pēru ēmiṭi*?

2.7 సంతోషం (*santōṣam*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is మిమ్మల్ని కలిసినందుకు సంతోషం (*mimmalni kalisinan-duku santōṣam*) — “joy at having met you.” The key word సంతోషం (*santōṣam*, “joy, gladness”) is **Sanskrit** (*sam-* + *toṣa*, “full satisfaction”), the *same* loan Kannada uses — both reach for Sanskrit where Tamil keeps its native *magilcci*. Telugu, the most Sanskritised of the four, does so most readily of all.

2.8 The whole exchange

Telugu		English
నా పేరు మీరా.	<i>nā pēru Mira</i>	My name is Mira.
మీ పేరు ఏమిటి?	<i>mī pēru ēmiṭi</i>	What’s your name?
నా పేరు అరుణ్.	<i>nā pēru Arun</i>	My name is Arun.
సంతోషం.	<i>santōṣam</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *pēru* (Dravidian *pēr, *not name*), *nā* (from *nēnu*, “I”), *ēmiṭi* (Dravidian question-stem) — and *santōṣam*, a Sanskrit loan for “pleased.” The Telugu habit: the **zero copula** (no “is”). Next chapter: *elā unnāru?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *bāgunnānu* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, a Telugu verb “to be”:

మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? (*mīru elā unnāru* — “How are you?”)
నేను బాగున్నాను, ధన్యవాదములు. (*nēnu bāgunnānu, dhanyavādamulu* —
“I’m well, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TE-C03-.md.*

3.1 ఎలా (*elā*) — “how,” another of the e- questions

The letters in this word

ఎ (independent short *e*) + లా (*lā*) → ఎలా (*elā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఎలా (*elā*, “how”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative base ఎ- (*e-*) from *ēmiṭi*. Telugu gathers nearly all its questions under this **e-**: *ēmiṭi* (what), *elā* (how), *evāru* (who), *ekkaḍa* (where), *eppuḍu* (when). It is the same Dravidian question-root heading Tamil’s *eppaṭi* and Kannada’s *ēnu* — a family older than the Sanskrit words Telugu otherwise borrows so freely.

3.2 మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? — “how are you?”

The new word is ఉన్నారు (*unnāru*, “you are”): from the verb ఉండు (*uṇḍu*, “to be, exist, stay”) + the respectful-you ending *-āru*. So మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు?

is “you how are?”, the verb last, as in every Telugu sentence.

Grammar Lens

The verb carries “you.” The ending *-āru* already means “you (respectful),” so *māru* can be dropped: *elā unnāru?* is a whole “how are you?” To a friend: నువ్వు ఎలా ఉన్నావు? (*nuvvu elā unnāvu?* — *-āvu* for the familiar “you”). Match the “you” to the verb-ending.

3.3 నేను (*nēnu*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

నే (*nē*) + ను (*nu*) → నేను (*nēnu*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నేను (*nēnu*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yān* / **nēn* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *maiṃ*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the నా (*nā*, “my”) you met in Chapter 2. For all the Sanskrit Telugu borrows elsewhere, its basic pronouns stayed Dravidian to the core.

3.4 బాగా (*bāgā*) — “well,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

బా (*bā*) + గా (*gā*) → బాగా (*bāgā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

బాగా (*bāgā*, “well, nicely, very”), from బాగు (*bāgu*, “goodness”), is the everyday “well/good/very.” To answer “how are you,” fuse it with the *uṇḍu* verb: నేను బాగున్నాను (*nēnu bāgunnānu*, “I am well” — *bāgā* + *unnānu* run together).

3.5 పరవాలేదు (*paravalēdu*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పరవాలేదు literally “**there is no harm**” — *paravā* (“harm”) + లేదు (*lēdu*, “is-not”), the Chapter-1 negative. It serves as “it’s okay / no worries / you’re welcome.” The atom లేదు (*lēdu*) is where Telugu goes its own way: Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam all say *illa(i)* for “is-not,” but **Telugu alone** uses *lēdu* — so Tamil’s “no problem” is *paravāyillai*, Telugu’s is *paravalēdu*, the same idea on each language’s own “not.”

Grammar Lens

లేదు (*lēdu*) negates existence: *ḍabbu lēdu* (“there’s no money”). It is the negative twin of ఉంది (*undi*, “there is”) and of the *uṇḍu* verb behind “how are you.” Hold *undi* / *lēdu* together — “there is” and “there is not.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Telugu	English
మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు?	How are you?
నేను బాగున్నాను, ధన్యవాదములు.	I’m well, thank you.
పరవాలేదు.	No problem / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *elā* (the native *e*- questions), *nēnu* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *bāgā* (“well”), and the *undi* / *lēdu* pair — “there is” and “there is not,” Telugu’s own “not” where its sisters use *illa*. Next chapter: the farewells — and Telugu, like all its family, never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Telugu, like every Dravidian language, does not say a plain “goodbye.” It promises to return:

వెళ్ళి వస్తాను. (*velli vastānu* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TE-CO4-.md.*

4.1 వెళ్ళు (*vellu*) — “go,” and వచ్చు (come)

The letters in this word

వె (*ve*) + ళ్ళు (*llu*, doubled retroflex శ *!*) → వెళ్ళు. Its partner వచ్చు (*vaccu*, “come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

వెళ్ళు (*vellu*, “to go”) and వచ్చు (*vaccu*, “to come”) are native Dravidian verbs. As commands they are whole words: *vellu!* (“go!”), *rā!* (“come!”). You need both, because Telugu’s goodbye is “I go, and I come back.”

4.2 వెళ్ళి వస్తాను (*velli vastānu*) — “I’ll go and come back”

వెళ్ళి (*veli*, “having gone”) + వస్తాను (*vastānu*, “I come”) — literally “**having gone, I come [back]**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Telugu speaker never

signs off with a bare “I’m leaving.” The warm reply is వెళ్లి రండి (*velli raṇḍi*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Tamil	<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varām</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)

The whole south, and beyond, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

4.3 రేపు కలుద్దాం (*rēpu kaluddām*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

రే (*rē*) + పు (*pu*) → రేపు. కలుద్దాం (*kaluddām*) = *kalu* (“meet”) + *-ddām* (“let’s”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

రేపు (*rēpu*, “tomorrow”) is native; కలు (*kalu*, “to meet, join”) gives *kaluddām* (“let’s meet”) — “tomorrow, let’s meet.” The -దాం (*-ddām*) ending is Telugu’s “let’s ...”: *velliddām* (“let’s go”), *tindām* (“let’s eat”).

4.4 మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం (*mallī kaluddām*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం = మళ్ళీ (*mallī*, “again”) + *kaluddām* (“let’s meet”). Both are native Dravidian: *mallī* (from *maral*, “to return”) and *kalu* (“meet”). Where Tamil’s “we’ll meet again” reaches for the Sanskrit loan *sandi* to say “meet,” Telugu keeps the native *kalu* — the same phrase, from different stock.

4.5 The farewells

Telugu	English
వెళ్ళి వస్తాను.	I’ll go and come back. (goodbye)
వెళ్ళి రండి.	Go and come back. (the reply)
రేపు కలుద్దాం.	See you tomorrow.
మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం.	We’ll meet again.

Roots banked: *vellu/vaccu* (go/come), *rēpu* (“tomorrow”), *kalu* (“meet,” native — where Tamil borrowed *sandi*), and *mallī* (“again”). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *nēnu telugu māṭlāḍatānu* — and Telugu’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and Telugu’s sentences begin to move:

నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను. (*nēnu telugu māṭṭlāḍatānu* — “I speak Telugu.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TE-C05-.md.*

5.1 మాట్లాడు (*māṭṭlāḍu*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

మా (*mā*) + ట్లా (*ṭlā*) + డు (*ḍu*) → మాట్లాడు.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

మాట్లాడు (*māṭṭlāḍu*, “to speak”) is native Dravidian, built on మాట (*māṭa*, “word, speech”). To say “I speak,” Telugu stacks two endings on the stem — tense then person:

māṭṭlāḍ- + *-t-* (present) + *-ānu* (“I”) → మాట్లాడతాను (*māṭṭlāḍatānu*), “I speak.”

The *-ānu* ending is “I,” so *nēnu* is rarely needed: *māṭṭlāḍtāḍu* (he), *māṭṭlāḍtundi* (she/it), *māṭṭlāḍtāru* (they / you-respectful).

Grammar Lens

Stem + tense + person. Every Telugu verb is built this way. And, like Tamil, Telugu marks **no gender in the first person**: *māṭḷāḍatānu* is the same for a man or a woman — unlike Hindi’s *boltā/boltī*.

5.2 నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను — “I speak Telugu”

నేను (I) + తెలుగు (*telugu*, the object) + మాట్లాడతాను (speak) — “I Telugu speak,” verb last. The name తెలుగు (*telugu*) is native, of debated origin; its vowel-rich sound and habit of ending most words in a vowel earned it the old nickname “**the Italian of the East**.” It is the tongue of the *Kāvya* poets and of some eighty million speakers today.

Grammar Lens

No gender on “I speak.” *Māṭḷāḍatānu* is the same whether a man or a woman says it — Telugu, like Tamil, marks no gender in the first or second person (only the third: *-āḍu* he, *-undi* she/it).

5.3 ఉండు (*uṇḍu*) — “to be, to stay, to live”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఉండు (*uṇḍu*, “to be, exist, stay, live”) is native Dravidian and does enormous work: it is the verb behind Chapter 3’s *unnāru* (“you are”) and *bāgunnānu* (“I’m well”), and it also means “to reside”: నేను హైదరాబాద్లో ఉంటాను (*nēnu Hyderābādlo uṇṭānu*, “I live in Hyderabad”). One verb covers “be,” “stay,” and “live.”

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. హైదరాబాద్లో (*Hyderābādlo*) = *Hyderabad* + -లో (*-lō*, “in”), glued to the *end* of the noun. Telugu uses **postpositions** (case-suffixes) where English uses prepositions: “Hyderabad-in I stay,” the verb last.

5.4 పని చేయు (*pani cēyu*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

చేయు (*cēyu*, “to do, make”) is a core native verb, and Telugu — like Hindi with *karnā* and Tamil with *sey* — builds compounds by putting a noun in front of it: పని చేయు (*pani cēyu*, “work-do” = “to work”), *vaṇṭa cēyu* (“to cook”), *sahāyaṇ cēyu* (“to help,” with a **Sanskrit** noun on the **native** *cēyu* — the two vocabularies in one verb). So “I work” is నేను పని చేస్తాను (*nēnu pani cēstānu*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + చేయు = a new verb — the exact twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*” and Tamil’s “noun + *sey*.” Three languages, two of them from unrelated families, all landed on the same trick.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Telugu	English
నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను.	I speak Telugu.
నేను హైదరాబాద్‌లో ఉంటాను.	I live in Hyderabad.
నేను పని చేస్తాను.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, the verb always last — and no gender in the first person. Roots banked: *māṭṭāḍu* (speak ← *māṭa* “word”), *uṇḍu* (be/stay/live, with *-lō* “in” on the noun’s end), and *cēyu* (do → *pani cēyu* “to work,” the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*). From here, Telugu’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Case Endings and Dative Subjects

6.1 -కు (-ku) — “to, for”

Your first **case ending**. English puts “to” in **front** as its own word. Telugu sticks it on the **back** — and that difference is the biggest structural fact about the language.

You’ll want to know: Adding it on

word	+ -ku	meaning
పేరు <i>pēru</i> — name	పేరుకు <i>pēruku</i>	to/for the name
పని <i>pani</i> — work	పనికి <i>paniki</i>	for work

Notice the suffix appears as **-కు** *-ku* or **-కి** *-ki* depending on the vowel before it. Same suffix, adjusted to fit — the seam still shows.

And with “I”, which changes its body first:

నేను *nēnu* (“I”) → నాకు *nāku* (“to me”)

Nēnu becomes *nā-* before the ending. Nouns don’t do this; they just take the suffix.

Grammar Lens: Why this matters

	Telugu -ku	a Latin ending like -īs
pins down the case?	yes — dative, always	no — <i>-īs</i> is dative or ablative
carries number?	no — a separate suffix does	yes — plural, baked in
carries declension class?	no	yes — 1st/2nd only
can you see the seam?	yes: <i>pēru + ku</i>	no — one fused lump

Telugu **stacks**: each suffix means one thing and sits in a fixed order, so you can point at every piece of a long word. Latin **fuses** — *-īs* is case *and* plural *and* declension, indivisible, and it doesn't even settle *which* case. Telugu's *-ku* is never ambiguous.

That's what “**agglutinative**” means, and it's why Telugu words grow long without growing hard: they are **built**, not memorised.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pēru ... pēruku*”
- “*nēnu ... nāku*” — “I” ... “to me”
- “*paniki*” — “for work,” from Ch. 5's పని
- the principle — “one suffix, one meaning, visible seam”

Before you move on

What does **-కు** mean? (“**To**” or “**for**.”) Where does it go? (**On the end** of the noun.) What is “to me”? (**నాకు** *nāku* — *nēnu* shrinks to *nā-* first.) Why does it sometimes appear as **-కి**? (It **adjusts to the preceding vowel** — same suffix.) How does that differ from Latin? (Latin **fuses** case+number+declension into one ending — and *-īs* doesn't even fix *which* case; Telugu's carries **one** meaning, unambiguously, with the **seam visible**.) Next: the sentence where Telugu leaves out the subject entirely.

6.2 నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు — “I know Telugu”

Chapter 5 taught you how to say “I speak Telugu.” Now say “I **know** Telugu.” Telugu won’t let you use *nēnu* — and the verb it uses instead will surprise you.

You’ll want to know: The sentence

నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు. *nāku telugu vaccu.* literally: “**to-me** Telugu comes.”

piece

నాకు <i>nāku</i>	“to me” — the dative from the last lesson
తెలుగు <i>telugu</i>	Telugu (Ch. 5)
వచ్చు <i>vaccu</i>	“ comes ” — the very verb you learned in Ch. 4

Two things at once. **You are not the subject** — *nēnu* is gone, moved into the dative, and what’s left unmarked is *telugu*. And the verb is literally “**to come**”: a language you know is a thing that **comes to you**.

Grammar Lens: Why: things that happen *to* you

Telugu sorts experiences from actions. Speaking is something you **do**, so Ch. 5 used *nēnu*. But knowing, liking, wanting, being hungry — these **arrive** at you. Telugu marks that by putting the person in the **dative**.

English frames it as	Telugu frames it as
I know Telugu	Telugu comes to me
I like it	it is pleasing to me
I am cold	cold is to me

English keeps one fossil of exactly this: “**methinks**” — *me* is a dative, “it seems **to me**.” Telugu made it the rule.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

language	“I know [the language]”	the dative
Telugu	<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	-ku
Tamil	<i>enakku tamīl teriyum</i>	-ukku
Kannada	<i>nanage kannada gottu</i>	-ge
Malayalam	<i>enikku malayālam ariyām</i>	-ikku

One construction across four languages, with four suffixes that are visibly the **same suffix** — *-ku* / *-ukku* / *-ge* / *-ikku*. The Dravidian family showing its bones, just as *blanc/bianco/branco* did for Romance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nāku telugu vaccu*”
- the contrast — “*nēnu telugu māṭṭādatānu*” (I speak) ... “*nāku telugu vaccu*” (comes to me)
- the literal — “to-me Telugu comes”
- the four cousins — “*-ku · -ukku · -ge · -ikku*”

Before you move on

What does నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు literally say? (“**To-me** Telugu **comes**.”) Which verb is doing the work, and where did you meet it? (వచ్చు “to come” — Chapter 4.) What has English got that Telugu hasn’t? (A nominative “**I**” — *nēnu* is replaced by the dative *nāku*.) Why the dative? (Knowing **happens** to you.) Which English word keeps the same idea? (**Methinks**.)

Chapter 7

Numbers One to Ten

7.1 ఒకటి, రెండు, మూడు, నాలుగు, ఐదు — one to five

Four of these five are old Dravidian friends. The very first one is Telugu going its own way.

You'll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
1	౧	ఒకటి	<i>okaṭi</i>
2	౨	రెండు	<i>reṇḍu</i>
3	౩	మూడు	<i>mūḍu</i>
4	౪	నాలుగు	<i>nālugu</i>
5	౫	ఐదు	<i>aidu</i>

The symbols ౧ ౨ ౩ ౪ ౫ are Telugu's own digits.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

One is where Telugu leaves the family. Its cousins agree — Tamil *onru*, Kannada *ondu*, Malayalam *onnu*, all from an old *on-* — but Telugu says **okaṭi**, a different formation altogether. It's the number to memorise fresh rather than reason across from Tamil.

From two onward, the family closes ranks again:

	Tamil	Telugu
2	<i>iraṇṭu</i>	reṇḍu
3	<i>mūṇru</i>	mūḍu
4	<i>nāṇku</i>	nālugu
5	<i>aintu</i>	aidu
<i>Reṇḍu</i> has simply dropped the opening vowel of <i>iraṇṭu</i> ; <i>mūḍu</i> is <i>mūṇru</i> with its cluster smoothed to a single ḍ . Same numbers, a Telugu polish.		

Script you'll notice: A Telugu shape to notice

Nearly every Telugu word here ends in **-u** (*reṇḍu*, *mūḍu*, *nālugu*) — the language's strong preference for open, vowel-final syllables. Even where Tamil ends hard, Telugu tends to round the word off with a vowel.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “okaṭi, reṇḍu, mūḍu, nālugu, aidu”
- the maverick — “okaṭi”, NOT the *onru*/ondu/onnu of its cousins
- the family — “iraṇṭu → reṇḍu”, the opening vowel dropped

Before you move on

Count to five in Telugu. (*Okaṭi*, *reṇḍu*, *mūḍu*, *nālugu*, *aidu*.) Which number does Telugu form unlike the rest of the family, and what do the others say? (**One** — Telugu *okaṭi* vs *onru* / *ondu* / *onnu*.) How does *reṇḍu* relate to Tamil *iraṇṭu*? (The opening vowel was dropped.) What vowel do most Telugu words here end in? (**-u**.) Next: six to ten.

7.2 ఆరు, ఏడు, ఎనిమిది, తొమ్మిది, పది — six to ten

The top of the count is where Telugu is least like its cousins — two of these you simply learn on their own.

You'll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
6	ఆ	ఆరు	<i>āru</i>
7	ఏ	ఏడు	<i>ēḍu</i>
8	ఐ	ఎనిమిది	<i>enimidi</i>
9	తొ	తొమ్మిది	<i>tommidi</i>
10	పది	పది	<i>padi</i>

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Six is an easy cousin (Tamil *āru* → Telugu *āru*). **Seven** is more interesting: Tamil *ēḷu* carries the rare **ḷ** (the *zh* of *Tamil*); Kannada hardened it to **ḷ** (*ēḷu*); **Telugu went further still** and turned it into a plain **ḍ** — *ēḍu*. One inherited sound, three fates across the three scripts.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here Telugu strays furthest from its cousins —

	Tamil	Malayalam	Telugu
8	<i>eṭṭu</i>	<i>eṭṭu</i>	enimidi
9	<i>onpatu</i>	<i>onpatu</i>	tommidi

You can't reach *enimidi* and *tommidi* from Tamil by regular sound-change the way you can *reṇḍu* from *iraṇṭu*: *tommidi* is a different word entirely, and *enimidi* — though it shares the ancient *eṇ*-root behind *eṭṭu* — has drifted too far to derive. So unlike 2–7, learn these two **fresh**.

Ten comes partly back into the fold — Telugu *padi* is a worn-down relative of the *pat*- in Tamil *pattu* (and the *-patu* hiding inside *tommidi* and Tamil *onpatu*, “one-to-ten”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āru, ēḍu, enimidi, tommidi, padi”
- seven's three fates — “Tamil *ēḷu*, Kannada *ēḷu*, Telugu *ēḍu*”
- the two you learn fresh — “enimidi, tommidi”

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Telugu. (*Āru*, *ēḍu*, *enimidi*, *tommidi*, *padi*.) What became of Tamil's **ḷ** (in *ēḷu*) by the time it reached Telugu *ēḍu*? (It hardened all the way to **ḍ**.) Which two numbers can't you derive from Tamil by regular correspondence? (**Eight and nine** — learn *enimidi*, *tommidi* fresh.) How does *padi* relate to Tamil *pattu*? (A worn-down relative of the same *pat*- “ten”.)

Chapter 8

Please

8.1 దయచేసి (dayacēsi) — please (having done compassion)

Telugu’s “please” carries a whole small sentence inside it: “having **done** (me) a compassion.”

You’ll want to know: The word

దయచేసి = **please**, literally “**having done kindness / compassion.**” Two pieces:

- దయ (*daya*) = **compassion, kindness, grace** — from Sanskrit **daya**.
- చేసి (*cēsi*) = “**having done,**” from the verb చేయు (*cēyu*) “to do.”

So *dayacēsi* is *having done (a) kindness* — you ask by crediting the listener with the grace you hope they’ll show.

It is the twin of **Tamil** *tayavu seytu* (“**do** the kindness”) — both use a “do” verb — and cousins with **Kannada** *dayaviṭṭu* (“having **placed** compassion”). Further off, **Arabic** *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”) and **Hindi** *kṛpayā* (from *kṛpā*, “**compassion**”) ask in the very same spirit.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

daya + a light verb, four ways:

- Telugu దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — compassion + **having done**
- Tamil தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu* — kindness + **do**

- Kannada ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu* — compassion + **having placed**
- Malayalam ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — compassion + **as / having become**

Why it's said this way

Honestly: the standalone word is somewhat **formal / emphatic**. Day-to-day, Telugu politeness rides on the **respectful command** ending -ఁడి (-*aṇḍi*): కూర్చోండి (*kūrcōṇḍi*) “please sit,” చెప్పండి (*ceppaṇḍi*) “please tell me.” That -*aṇḍi* is already “please.” Put దయచేసి in front to warm it further.

Script you'll notice: Sound & structure point

The middle syllable చే is *ca* wearing the **long-ē** sign -ే (the counterpart of the short-e sign -ె), giving *cē*; then సి is *sa* + the *i* sign (-ి). Telugu marks a vowel's length and quality by the little sign riding on the consonant — the consonant stays put, the vowel-sign changes the tune.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “daya” — compassion — then “cēsi,” having done
- the whole word — “dayacēsi” = please
- the everyday way — the verb ending: “kūrcōṇḍi” = please sit

Before you move on

What is the Telugu word for please? (దయచేసి *dayacēsi*.) What do its pieces mean? (“**Compassion**” *daya* + “**having done**” *cēsi*.) Which cousins ask the same way? (**Tamil, Kannada, Malayalam** with *daya* — plus **Arabic** *fadl*, **Hindi** *kṛpā*.) What carries “please” in ordinary speech? (**The respectful verb ending** -ఁడి -*aṇḍi*.)

Chapter 9

Sorry

9.1 క్షమించండి — sorry

You already know దయచేసి and its respectful -ండి ending (*kūr-cōṇḍi*, “please sit”). Telugu’s “sorry” hands you that very ending again, riding a brand-new verb.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- క్షమా (*kṣamā*) = “**forgiveness, patience**” — the Sanskrit noun, borrowed whole.
- -ఇంచు (*-iṅcu*) = a **verb-making suffix**: *kṣamā* + *-iṅcu* → క్షమించు (*kṣamiṅcu*), “**to forgive**.” (The same pattern gives ప్రారంభించు *prārambhīṅcu*, “to begin,” from Sanskrit *prārambha*.)
- -ండి (*-aṇḍi*) = the **respectful imperative** ending — exactly the one you already met on *kūr-cōṇḍi* “please sit” and *ceppaṇḍi* “please tell me.”

So క్షమించండి is “**please forgive**” — the same polite mold you already know, filled with a new verb.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- Telugu క్షమించండి *kṣamiṅcaṇḍi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-iṅcu** (verb) + **-aṇḍi** (imperative)
- Kannada ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ *kṣamisi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-isu** (verb) + **-i** (imperative)

- Malayalam ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkaṇaṁ* — Sanskrit *kṣama* + **-ikkuka** (verb) + **-aṇaṁ** (necessitative)
- Tamil மன்னிக்கவும் *mannikkavum* — its **own** native root *manni*, not Sanskrit at all

Why it's said this way

క్షమించండి is a real, everyday “sorry / please forgive me” — not stiffly formal — though in quick, casual exchanges Telugu speakers just as often reach for the borrowed English “**sorry.**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kṣamā” — the Sanskrit noun, forgiveness
- the verb — “kṣamiṇcu,” to forgive — then “kṣamiṇcaṇḍi,” please forgive
- the ending you already know — “-aṇḍi,” same as *kūrcōṇḍi*

Before you move on

What is క్షమించండి built from? (Sanskrit *kṣamā* + the verb-making suffix **-iṇcu** + the respectful ending **-aṇḍi**, which you already met on *kūrcōṇḍi*.) Which cousins also verb-ify *kṣamā*, and which doesn't? (Kannada and Malayalam do too; Tamil uses its own root *manni*.) What's the casual alternative? (Borrowed English “**sorry.**”)

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

10.1 సోమవారం to ఆదివారం — Telugu’s week, with a twist on Sunday

Like Kannada, Telugu’s week runs on Sanskrit deity-names — but its Sunday breaks the “planet” pattern entirely, in a way even Kannada’s doesn’t.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu	deity/planet	day
సోమవారం (<i>Somavāram</i>)	Moon (Soma)	Monday
మంగళవారం (<i>Maṅgalavāram</i>)	Mars (Maṅgala)	Tuesday
బుధవారం (<i>Budhavāram</i>)	Mercury (Budha)	Wednesday
గురువారం (<i>Guruvāram</i>)	Jupiter (Guru/Brhaspati)	Thursday
శుక్రవారం (<i>Śukravāram</i>)	Venus (Śukra)	Friday
శనివారం (<i>Śanivāram</i>)	Saturn (Śani)	Saturday
ఆదివారం (<i>Ādivāram</i>)	— not a planet at all	Sunday

Why it’s said this way

Five days match the familiar planet-deity pattern — but ఆదివారం (*Ādivāram*) doesn’t name the Sun at all. ఆది (*ādi*) is Sanskrit for “the

beginning, the first.” So Telugu’s Sunday literally means “**the first day**” — a **positional** name, like Arabic’s numbered weekdays, sitting right next to six planet-names that don’t work that way. Even within one single week, a language can mix completely different naming strategies.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Somavāram, Maṅgalavāram, Budhavāram, Guruvāram, Śukravāram, Śanivāram” — Monday through Saturday
- the odd one — “Ādivāram” — not a planet, “the first day”
- the parallel — like Arabic’s numbered days, one Telugu day is positional too

Before you move on

What does ఆదివారం literally mean, and is it a planet-name? (“**The first day**” — ādi “beginning” — **not** a planet-name, unlike the other six.) What ending do the other six Telugu weekdays share? (-వారం -vāram, Sanskrit “day,” each paired with a planet-deity.)

Chapter 11

Four Core Colours

11.1 నలుపు, తెలుపు, ఎరుపు, నీలం — the pattern completes itself

By now the shape should feel familiar: native colors for black, white, and red — and one shared Sanskrit word for blue. Telugu confirms it a fourth time.

You'll want to know: Three native colors

- నలుపు (*nalupu*) = “**black**” — native Dravidian.
- తెలుపు (*telupu*) = “**white**” — native Dravidian.
- ఎరుపు (*erupu*) = “**red**” — native Dravidian.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నీలం (*nīlam*) = “**blue**” — the identical Sanskrit नील (*nīla*) loan you’ve now seen in Tamil (*nīlam*), Malayalam (*nīla*), Kannada (*nīli*), and Hindi (*nīlā*). Four Dravidian languages plus Hindi, all independently keeping their own native black/white/red, and all reaching for the **exact same** borrowed word the moment it comes to blue.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nalupu, telupu, erupu” — black, white, red
- “nīlam” — blue, the word every language in this course now shares

- the whole pattern, one more time — native, native, native,
borrowed

Before you move on

What's the pattern across Tamil, Malayalam, Kannada, and Telugu's basic colors? (**Black, white, and red are native Dravidian words in every one of them; blue is a shared Sanskrit loan (nīla) in every one of them.**)

Chapter 12

Family

12.1 నాన్న, అమ్మ, and four sibling words — Telugu’s own twist

Telugu also sorts siblings by relative age. Its words for “father” and “younger sister,” though, go their own way.

You’ll want to know: Parents — one matches, one is Telugu’s own

- నాన్న (*nānna*) = “**father**” — **Telugu’s own word**, unlike Tamil/Kannada’s *appā/appa*.
- అమ్మ (*amma*) = “**mother**” — matches Tamil/Kannada’s *ammā/amma* closely.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu	meaning	compare Tamil/Kannada
అన్న (anna)	older brother	<i>aṇṇan/aṇṇa</i> — near match
తమ్ముడు (tammudu)	younger brother	<i>tambi/tamma</i> — near match
అక్క (akka)	older sister	<i>akkā/akka</i> — near match
చెల్లి (celli)	younger sister	<i>tangai/tangi</i> — Telugu's own word here

So the *system* — four words, split by relative age rather than just gender — is shared across Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu. But the exact words aren't identical everywhere: Telugu keeps its own నాన్న for father and చెల్లి for “younger sister,” even while three of the six words line up closely with its cousins.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nānna, amma” — father, mother
- “anna, tammudu” — older/younger brother
- “akka, celli” — older/younger sister — celli is Telugu's own

Before you move on

Which two Telugu family words are its own, rather than matching Tamil/Kannada? (నాన్న *nānna*, “father,” and చెల్లి *celli*, “younger sister.”) Does Telugu still split siblings by age the same way? (**Yes** — the four-way age-before-gender system is shared across the whole Dravidian family, even where the exact words differ.)

Chapter 13

Head and Hand

13.1 తల, చెయ్యి — head and hand

Head matches its cousins plainly. Hand looks, at first glance, like Telugu went its own way — but look closer, and it’s the same word after all, just heavily reshaped.

You’ll want to know: The words

- తల (*tala*) = “**head**” — native Dravidian, matching Tamil *talai*, Malayalam *thala*, and Kannada *tale* closely and plainly.
- చెయ్యి (*ceyyi*) = “**hand**” — also native Dravidian, and **the very same root** as Tamil/Malayalam/Kannada’s *kai*: Proto-Dravidian *kay-*. Telugu’s own regular sound change turned that ancient **k-** into **c-**, and reshaped the rest of the word alongside it — so *ceyyi* only *looks* unrelated to *kai*. It’s a cognate in disguise, not a different word.

So all four Dravidian languages actually **agree** on both “head” and “hand” at the root level — Telugu’s hand-word has simply drifted further in sound than its cousins have, thanks to a sound change that reshaped many Telugu words the same way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tala” — head, matching its cousins plainly
- “ceyyi” — hand, the SAME root as *kai*, reshaped by sound change

- the lesson — looks different, is actually the same word

Before you move on

Does Telugu's word for "head" match its cousins? (**Yes** — *tala*, like Tamil/Malayalam/Kannada.) Is its word for "hand," *ceyyi*, truly a different word from *kai*? (**No** — it's the **same Proto-Dravidian root** *kay-*, reshaped by Telugu's own regular $k \rightarrow c$ sound change — a cognate in disguise, not an unrelated word.)

Chapter 14

Seasons

14.1 వసంత ఋతువు, వేసవి, వానాకాలం, శీతాకాలం — the pattern completes itself

Telugu closes out the Dravidian season words the same way Kannada did: native words for summer/rain/cold, and a spring-word borrowed twice over from Sanskrit.

You’ll want to know: The words

Telugu	meaning	source
వసంత ఋతువు (<i>vasanta ṛtuvu</i>)	“spring”	both <i>vasanta</i> and ఋతువు <i>ṛtuvu</i> (“season”) are Sanskrit, like Kannada’s pair
వేసవి (<i>vēsavi</i>)	“summer”	native Dravidian — cousin of Kannada’s <i>bēsige</i>
వానాకాలం (<i>vānākālam</i>)	“rainy season”	వాన <i>vāna</i> (“rain,” native) + <i>kālam</i> (“time,” itself Sanskrit-derived but long assimilated)
శీతాకాలం (<i>śītākālam</i>)	“winter/cold season”	<i>śīta</i> (“cold”) leans Sanskrit-flavored here, unlike Tamil/Kannada’s fully native cold-words

Why it’s said this way

Telugu’s *vēsavi* and Kannada’s *bēsige* are close enough in shape to be genuine cousins — the same native Dravidian summer-word wearing two languages’ sound changes. And once again, it’s వానాకాలం (*vānākālam*, the rains) that actually organizes Andhra/Telangana’s agricultural year, not a clean four-way Western split — the same honest point every language in this arc has made.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vēsavi” — summer, cousin of Kannada’s *bēsige*
- “vānākālam” — the rains, the real central season
- “śītākālam” — the cold season
- the double Sanskrit loan — “vasanta ṛtuvu,” like Kannada

Before you move on

What's the relationship between Telugu's *vēsavi* and Kannada's *bēsige*? (**Cousins** — the same native Dravidian summer-word.) Which Dravidian languages borrow BOTH halves of their spring-word from Sanskrit (the season-name AND the word for “season” itself)? (**Kannada and Telugu** — *vasanta ṛtu(vu)* — unlike Tamil/Malayalam's single *vasantham* loan plus the long-assimilated *kaalam*.)

Chapter 15

Water and Rice

15.1 నీళ్లు, బియ్యం, అన్నం — water and rice

Water closes out 3-against-1 against Malayalam. Rice, though, turns out to have its own twist here.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నీళ్లు (*nīḷḷu*) = “**water**” — matching Tamil’s *nīr* and Kannada’s *nīru*. Malayalam’s *vellam* is the odd one out among all four Dravidian languages for water, not Telugu.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- బియ్యం (*biyyam*) = “**rice**” (raw grain) — **Telugu’s own word**, unlike the shared *ari/arisi/akki* found in Malayalam, Tamil, and Kannada.
- అన్నం (*annam*) = “**cooked rice**” (the meal) — matching Kannada’s *anna* closely, both likely Sanskrit-influenced.

So the pattern flips between water and rice: for **water**, Telugu joins the majority (Tamil/Kannada) against Malayalam; for **raw rice**, Telugu is itself the odd one out against the other three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nīḷḷu” — water, matching Tamil/Kannada

- “biyyam” — raw rice, Telugu’s own word
- “annam” — cooked rice, matching Kannada’s anna

Before you move on

Which language is the odd one out for water, and which for raw rice? (**Malayalam** is the odd one out for water (*vellam*); **Telugu** is the odd one out for raw rice (*biyyam*, unlike the shared *ari/arisi/akki* elsewhere).)

Chapter 16

The Traditional Months

16.1 చైత్రం to ఫాల్గుణం — completing the split

The pattern across all four Dravidian languages is now complete: Telugu, like Kannada, shares its calendar with Hindi rather than building its own.

You'll want to know: The twelve months

The year runs in three four-month groups:

- చైత్రం, వైశాఖం, జ్యేష్ఠం, ఆషాఢం — *Caitraṇi, Vaiśākhaṇi, Jyēṣṭhaṇi, Āṣāḍhaṇi*.
- శ్రావణం, భాద్రపదం, ఆశ్వయుజం, కార్తీకం — *Śrāvaṇaṇi, Bhādrapadaṇi, Āśvayujaṇi, Kārtikaṇi*.
- మార్గశిరం, పుష్యం, మాఘం, ఫాల్గుణం — *Mārgaśiraṇi, Puṣyaṇi, Māghaṇi, Phālgunaṇi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

This closes out a genuine, clean split across the four Dravidian languages: **Tamil** and **Malayalam** each built their **own** solar calendar (nakshatra-named and zodiac-named, respectively) — while **Kannada** and **Telugu** instead share the **same pan-Indian Sanskritic lunisolar calendar** as Hindi's Vikram Samvat. Telugu's New Year, **Ugadi**, falls on the very same day as Kannada's — *Chaitra Śuddha Pādyami*, the first day of Chaitra's bright fortnight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Caitraṁ, Vaiśākhaṁ, Jyēṣṭhaṁ, Āṣāḍhaṁ, Śrāvaṇaṁ, Bhādrapadaṁ, Āśvayujaṁ, Kārtikaṁ, Mārgaśīraṁ, Puṣyaṁ, Māghaṁ, Phālgunaṁ”
- “Ugadi — Chaitra Śuddha Pādyami”
- the whole family split — Tamil/Malayalam their own; Kannada/Telugu shared with Hindi

Before you move on

How does the four-language Dravidian calendar picture split? (**Tamil and Malayalam** each have their **own** solar calendar; **Kannada and Telugu** share the **same pan-Indian lunisolar calendar** as Hindi.) What is Telugu’s New Year, and when does it fall? (**Ugadi**, on *Chaitra Śuddha Pādyami* — the same day as Kannada’s Ugadi.)

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

17.1 మధ్యాహ్నం, అర్ధరాత్రి — the same noon word, a different midnight word

Telugu and Kannada share the exact same Sanskrit word for noon — but then quietly part ways on midnight.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

మధ్యాహ్నం (*madhyāhnam*) = “**noon, midday**” — the same Sanskrit *tat-sama* compound as Kannada’s *madhyāhna*: మధ్య (*madhya*, “**middle**”) + అహ్న (*ahna*, “**day**”), plus Telugu’s own -ం (*anusvāra*) ending. Same root, same meaning, same everyday register in both languages.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

అర్ధరాత్రి (*ardharātri*) = “**midnight**” — but here Telugu reaches for a **different** Sanskrit root: అర్ధ (*ardha*, “**half**”), not *madhya* (“middle”). Paired with రాత్రి (*rātri*, “**night**”), it literally means “**half-night**” — structurally the same shape as Hindi’s colloquial *ādhī rāt* (“half night”) and Latin’s transparent *media nox* pattern, but built from Sanskrit’s own dedicated “half” word rather than “middle.”

Grammar Lens: Be honest: two different “middle-ish” ideas, side by side

Don’t assume *madhya* and *ardha* are the same word wearing different clothes — they’re genuinely **separate Sanskrit roots** (“middle” vs. “half”) that happen to land on the same meaning here, the way English “midday” and “half the day gone” would both point at noon without

sharing a root. Telugu’s noon word keeps Kannada’s “middle” logic; its midnight word switches to “half” logic instead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “madhyāhnam” — noon, same root as Kannada
- “ardharātri” — midnight, literally “half-night”
- the contrast — “madhya” (middle) for noon, “ardha” (half) for midnight — two different Sanskrit roots

Before you move on

Does Telugu’s noon word match Kannada’s? (**Yes** — both *madhyāhna(m)*, from *madhya*, “middle.”) Does Telugu’s midnight word use the same root? (**No** — *ardharātri* uses **ardha**, “half,” a different Sanskrit root.) What does *ardharātri* literally mean? (“**Half-night**” — the same shape as Hindi’s *ādhī rāt*.)

Chapter 18

Telling Time

18.1 గంಟ — matching Kannada and Hindi’s “bell” word exactly

Telugu completes a clean three-way match: Hindi, Kannada, and now Telugu all use the same Sanskrit “bell” word for “hour.”

You’ll want to know: గంಟ — bell AND hour, a third time

గంಟ (*ganṭa*) = “**hour**” — and, exactly like Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā* and Kannada’s *gaṇṭe*, it means “**bell, clapper**” just as commonly, from the same Sanskrit घण्टा (*ghaṇṭā*). Same word, same bell-strikes-the-hour logic, three languages in a row.

Why it’s said this way

So on this concept, the split isn’t “Hindi vs. all four Dravidian languages” — **Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu** all share the Sanskrit *ghaṇṭā* (“bell”) root. **Tamil** most likely goes its own way with a native Dravidian word instead (though even specialists don’t call this fully settled). **Malayalam** is the genuinely surprising one: its cognate word, *maṇi*, is ALSO Sanskrit-derived per its own dictionaries — just from a **different** Sanskrit word, *maṇi* (“gem”), not *ghaṇṭā*. So three of these four languages likely trace their hour-word to Sanskrit, just not all to the *same* Sanskrit word — worth remembering that a Sanskrit/native split isn’t fixed per language, and isn’t always a clean binary either.

Grammar Lens: telling the time

ఒక గంట. — “One o’clock.” (*oka gaṇṭa*, “one hour/bell”)
 రెండు గంటలు. — “Two o’clock.” (*reṇḍu gaṇṭalu* — *gaṇṭa*
 takes its plural form, *gaṇṭalu*, once the count passes one)

Notice Telugu’s *gaṇṭa* pluralizes to *gaṇṭalu* for “two o’clock” onward — a small grammatical wrinkle Kannada’s *gaṇṭe* didn’t show you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gaṇṭa” — hour, also “bell”
- “oka gaṇṭa” — one o’clock
- “reṇḍu gaṇṭalu” — two o’clock, plural *gaṇṭalu*

Before you move on

What Sanskrit word do గంట, Kannada’s *gaṇṭe*, and Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā* all share? (घण्टा, *ghaṇṭā*, “bell.”) Which Dravidian language most likely does NOT use this Sanskrit word for “hour”? (**Tamil** — most likely a native Dravidian word instead.) Does Malayalam’s cognate word skip Sanskrit entirely too? (**No** — it’s Sanskrit-derived too, per its own dictionaries, just from a *different* Sanskrit word, *maṇi*, “gem.”) What happens to *gaṇṭa* for “two o’clock”? (It **pluralizes** to *gaṇṭalu*.)

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

19.1 నీ వయసెంత? — matching Kannada's simple possessive exactly

Telugu matches Kannada closely here — same Sanskrit word, same verbless grammar, just fused together by ordinary Telugu vowel sandhi.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

వయస్సు (*vayasu*) = “age” — the exact same Sanskrit वयस् (*vayas*, “age, vigor, strength,” PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*) you just met in Kannada.

Grammar Lens: fused by sandhi, still verbless

నీ వయసెంత? — “How old are you?” — literally “**your age how-much?**” (*nī vayas-enta?* — from *nī vayasu* + *enta*, “how much,” fused by regular vowel sandhi into *vayasenta*.)
నా వయస్సు ఇరవై. — “I am twenty years old.” — literally “**my age [is] twenty.**” (*nā vayasu iravai*.)

Same shape as Kannada: a plain possessive (“your/my age”) sitting next to the number, **no verb at all**. The only wrinkle is surface-level: everyday spoken Telugu often **fuses** *vayasu* + *enta* into one word, *vayasenta*, the same kind of vowel sandhi you’d see fusing any two Telugu words in fast speech — the underlying grammar is identical to Kannada’s, just written closer together.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vayasu” — age
- “nī vayasenta?” — how old are you?
- “nā vayasu iravai” — I am twenty, “my age [is] twenty”

Before you move on

Is Telugu’s వయస్సు the same Sanskrit word as Kannada’s *vayassu*? (**Yes** — both from *vayas*, PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*.) What happens to *vayasu* + *enta* in “nī vayasenta?”? (They **fuse** by ordinary vowel sandhi.) Does Telugu use a verb to state age, like Kannada? (**No** — same verbless possessive shape.)

Chapter 20

Numbers 11–20 and Weather

20.1 పదకొండు, ఇరవై — the same pattern, worn down one step further

You just watched Kannada’s twenty split cleanly into “two” + “ten.” Telugu most likely comes from the exact same pattern — but centuries of extra erosion have worn it past the point of being visible today.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu’s teens echo పది (*padi*, “ten”) plus each digit — పదకొండు (*padakonḍu*, 11), పన్నెండు (*panneṇḍu*, 12), and onward through పందొమ్మిది (*paṇḍommidi*, 19) — the same “digit + ten-echo” compounding you just saw in Kannada.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఇరవై (*iravai*, “twenty”) most likely continues the **same** pan-Dravidian pattern as Kannada’s *ippattu* — an old ***iru-/*renḍu** (“two”) root fused with an old “ten” root — but here’s the honest difference: centuries of sound change have worn *iravai* down far enough that it no longer visibly splits into “two” and “ten” on the surface, the way Kannada’s *ippattu* still does today. Telugu’s own word for “two,” రెండు (*renḍu*), doesn’t obviously show up inside *iravai* anymore — treat this as the most likely comparative-Dravidian account rather than a transparent, easily re-derivable compound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “padakoṇḍu, pannoṇḍu” — 11, 12
- “padi” — ten
- “iravai” — twenty, most likely the same “two-tens” idea as Kannada, just worn down further

Before you move on

How are Telugu’s teens built? (పది (ten) + a digit, compounded.) Does ఇరవై visibly split into “two” + “ten” today, the way Kannada’s *ippattu* does? (No — it most likely continues the same pan-Dravidian pattern, but erosion has worn away the visible split.) What’s Telugu’s word for “two”? (రెండు, *renḍu*.)

20.2 వాతావరణం — “the covering of air,” pure Sanskrit this time

Kannada’s weather word mixed a Persian loan with a Sanskrit one. Telugu’s is different again — a single, unmixed Sanskrit compound.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

వాతావరణం (*vātāvaraṇam*) = “**weather, atmosphere**” — built entirely from Sanskrit:

- వాత (*vāta*, “**wind, air**”) — the same Sanskrit root behind వాయువు (*vāyuvu*, “wind,” and the wind-god Vāyu).
- ఆవరణ (*āvaraṇa*, “**covering, layer, enclosure**”).

So *vātāvaraṇam* literally means “**the covering of air**” — the layer of air surrounding everything, i.e., the atmosphere/weather. Unlike Kannada’s *havāmāna* (Persian *hava* + Sanskrit *māna*), **both** pieces here are Sanskrit — no Perso-Arabic loan involved at all.

Grammar Lens: వర్షం పడుతోంది — “rain is falling”

వర్షం పడుతోంది. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**rain is falling.**” (*varṣaṁ paḍutōndi.*) — వర్షం (*varṣaṁ*, “rain”) is the same Sanskrit root, *varṣā*, you’ll see again in the Dravidian arc.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vātāvaraṇam” — weather, “the covering of air”
- “vāta” — wind/air, “āvaraṇa” — covering
- “varṣaṁ paḍutōndi” — it’s raining, “rain is falling”

Before you move on

What are the two Sanskrit pieces of వాతావరణం, and what does the whole word literally mean? (వాత, “air,” + ఆవరణ, “covering” — “**the covering of air.**”) Is either piece a Persian/Arabic loan, like part of Kannada’s word? (**No** — both pieces are Sanskrit.) What word does Telugu use for “rain”? (వర్షం, *varṣaṁ*.)

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

21.1 కుక్క, పిల్లి — the odd one out, and the word that most likely closes the loop

Kannada just gave you a rock-solid native dog-word. Telugu breaks from that pattern — but its cat-word may be the single most important word in this whole arc.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

కుక్క (*kukka*, “dog”) does **not** clearly continue the same నాయ-family root shared by Kannada, Malayalam, and Tamil. Its origin is honestly debated: some linguists propose it’s **onomatopoeic**, imitating the sound of a bark; others propose a borrowing from **Sanskrit** कुक्कुर (*kukkura*, itself a similarly-shaped word for dog). Neither is settled — but either way, Telugu’s everyday dog-word genuinely doesn’t match its closest cousins.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పిల్లి (*pilli*, “cat”) is a real, documented **Proto-Dravidian** root, **pillV* — with cognates surviving as **rarer, alternate** words for cat in both Tamil and Kannada. Here’s why this word matters for the **whole** arc: Sanskrit’s word for cat, बिडाल (*biḍāla*) — the word behind Hindi’s बिल्ली (*billī*), which you met as “most likely” borrowed from Dravidian, without a confirmed specific source — most likely traces back to **this exact root**. So Telugu’s everyday word for “cat” is most likely the closest living relative of the very word Sanskrit borrowed, tying together Latin’s *cattus*/Arabic’s *qitt* story on one side and Hindi’s *billī* story on the other,

all within this single course.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kukka” — dog, genuinely different from its Dravidian cousins
- “pilli” — cat, most likely the source behind Hindi’s billī

Before you move on

Does కుక్క continue the same root as Kannada’s *nāyi*? (**No** — genuinely different, debated between onomatopoeia and a Sanskrit loan.)
 What is పిల్లి most likely the source of? (**Sanskrit’s** बिडाल, *biḍāla* — and so Hindi’s बिल्ली, *billī*.)

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

22.1 పచ్చ, పసుపు — two colors, one Dravidian root

In Kannada, green stayed native but yellow got borrowed from Sanskrit. Telugu tells a tighter story: its green word and its yellow word turn out to be **doublets of the same root**, wearing two different faces.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పచ్చ (pacca, “green”) comes from **Proto-Dravidian** **pac-* — the same root already behind Tamil’s பச்சை (*paccai*) and Kannada’s ಹಸಿರು (*hasiru*, via Old Kannada *pasir*). No surprise here; this is the same pan-Dravidian green family from the last lesson.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పసుపు (pasupu, “yellow, turmeric”) is, remarkably, **also** a direct descendant of that **same** Proto-Dravidian **pac-* root — a true **doublet** of *pacca* itself, not a separate borrowing the way Kannada’s *haladi* was. Tamil even keeps a matching cognate, பசுப்பு (*pacuppu*), sitting alongside its own *paccai*. So where Kannada split green and yellow into two unrelated families (native Dravidian vs. a Sanskrit turmeric-loan), Telugu kept **both** colors inside the same native word-family — *pacca* and *pasupu* are, at root, doublets of the same word, one settling on “green” and the other on “yellow, turmeric-colored.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “పచ్చ” — green, from Proto-Dravidian *pac-*
- “పసుపు” — yellow/turmeric, a true doublet of *pacca*, same root
- the contrast with Kannada — Telugu kept both colors in one native family; Kannada’s yellow broke away as a Sanskrit loan

Before you move on

Are పచ్చ and పసుపు two unrelated words, or doublets of the same root? (**Doublets** — both from Proto-Dravidian **pac-*.) Does Telugu’s yellow word follow the same pattern as Kannada’s *haḷadi* (a Sanskrit loan)? (**No** — Telugu kept its yellow word native, unlike Kannada.) What Tamil word is *pasupu*’s direct cognate? (பசுப்பு, *pacuppu*.)

Chapter 23

Day

23.1 రోజు (rōju) — “day,” a genuine Persian surprise

You might expect Telugu’s word for “day” to be Sanskrit, like Kannada’s *dina*, or native Dravidian. It’s neither — it’s Persian.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

రోజు (rōju) — “day” — is Telugu’s everyday, ordinary word for “a day.” Here’s the real surprise: it’s **borrowed from Classical Persian** روز (rōz) — the same root, ultimately, as the Persian day names hiding in words like “Nowruz” (“new day”). Persian *rōz* itself traces to a Proto-Indo-European root, **lewk-* (“bright”) — a **completely different** PIE root from the **dyew-* family behind Latin’s *diēs*, Hindi’s *din*, and Kannada’s *dina*. Both roots independently mean something like “shining, bright” — but they are **not** cousins; this is convergent meaning, not shared ancestry.

Why it’s said this way

Telugu also has దినము (dinamu) — the same Sanskrit **tatsama** word as Kannada’s *dina*. But here’s the honest twist: unlike Kannada, where *dina* is the plain, everyday word, Telugu’s దినము is the more **formal, literary** alternate — *rōju* does the everyday work instead. Telugu’s formal/everyday split runs the **opposite direction** from Kannada’s.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rōju” — “day,” a genuine Persian loanword
- the honest surprise — from Persian rōz, PIE *lew-*, *NOT the same root as diēs/din/dina*
- the reversed pattern — dinamu is Telugu’s FORMAL word, unlike Kannada’s plain dina

Before you move on

What language does Telugu’s everyday రోజు (*rōju*) come from? (**Persian** — *rōz*.) Is Persian *rōz*’s PIE root the same as Latin *diēs*/Hindi *din*/Kannada *dina*’s root? (**No** — a completely different PIE root, **lew-*, “bright,” vs. **dyew-* — related in meaning, not in ancestry.) Is Telugu’s Sanskrit word, దినము (*dinamu*), the everyday word or the formal one? (**The formal one** — the opposite of Kannada, where *dina* is plain and everyday.)

Chapter 24

Night

24.1 రాత్రి (rātri) — “night,” this time matching the expected pattern

Last lesson’s *rōju* broke every expectation. This one is more straightforward — but still worth checking honestly, not assuming.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

రాత్రి (rātri) — “**night**” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama** word, already hiding inside అర్ధరాత్రి (*ardharātri*, “midnight,” Chapter 17). Unlike *rōju*’s Persian surprise, *rātri* really **is** Telugu’s ordinary, everyday word for “night” — matching Kannada’s own pattern this time, not breaking it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu **does** have native words here — but be honest: it’s a **messier** picture than Kannada’s clean two-word story, not a tidy mirror of it.

- రేయి (rēyi) — attested in older Telugu literature; most sources treat it as inherited Dravidian, though some grammars instead link it to *rātri* itself, so its native status is less than fully settled.
- మాపు (māpu) — its **primary** sense is actually “**evening, dusk**” (as in రేపుమాపు, “morning and evening”), with “night” only a secondary, extended sense — not a clean synonym for *rātri*.
- ఇరులు (irulu) — a genuine cognate of Kannada’s ಇರುಳು (*irulu*), but its primary modern sense is “**darkness**,” archaic even in that use.

All three have been effectively pushed aside by the Sanskrit loan — but unlike Kannada’s single native competitor, Telugu’s “native” side is split across three words in three different, overlapping senses.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rātri” — “night,” already met inside ardharātri
- rēyi, māpu, irulu — three native words, three overlapping senses, all pushed aside
- the contrast with last lesson — day broke the pattern, night matches it

Before you move on

Where have you already met రాత్రి before this lesson? (అర్ధరాత్రి, *ardharātri*, “midnight.”) Does *rātri* follow the same “Sanskrit-as-everyday” pattern as Kannada’s *rātri*, or does it break the pattern the way *rōju* did for “day”? (**It matches** — *rātri* really is Telugu’s everyday word.) Does Telugu’s native-word story cleanly mirror Kannada’s single-word *irulu*? (**No** — it’s messier: three words, రేయి/మాపు/ఇరులు, in three overlapping senses, not one clean replacement.)

Chapter 25

Good Night

25.1 శుభ రాత్రి (śubha rātri) — the standard translation, honestly checked against real speech

You have both pieces already: *rātri* from last lesson, and one more Sanskrit word. But this lesson’s honest twist is about who actually says the result out loud.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

శుభ రాత్రి (śubha rātri) — “good night” — literally “**auspicious night**.” Both pieces are Sanskrit **tatsama**: రాత్రి (*rātri*, “night,” already met) plus శుభ (*śubha*, “**auspicious**,” from root śubh, “to be beautiful,” ultimately PIE **kewb^h-*).

Why it’s said this way

Here’s a genuinely interesting wrinkle, hedged appropriately: some sources describe modern Telugu speakers, especially casually, often **code-switching to English** “good night” rather than saying శుభ రాత్రి aloud — treating it more as the standard written/dictionary translation than an everyday spoken phrase. Be careful with this claim, though: the evidence for it comes mainly from informal language-learning blogs and forum posts, not rigorous sociolinguistic sources, and the same “code-switch to English for casual farewells” pattern plausibly shows up across other South Asian languages too — it isn’t clearly something unique to Telugu, just something the available sources happened to mention for Telugu specifically. Either way, *śubha rātri* itself is perfectly correct and understood Telugu, whatever its actual spoken

frequency turns out to be.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha rātri” — “good night,” literally “auspicious night”
- śubha’s own root — śubh, “to be beautiful” → “auspicious”
- the honest twist — the standard translation, but many speakers code-switch to English instead

Before you move on

What does శుభ రాత్రి literally mean? (“**Auspicious night.**”) Is *śubha rātri* actually the phrase most Telugu speakers say aloud for “good night”? (**Often not** — many code-switch to English “good night” in casual speech; *śubha rātri* is the standard written/ formal translation.) Does this mean *śubha rātri* is wrong or ungrammatical? (**No** — perfectly correct, just less commonly spoken than expected.)

Chapter 26

Morning

26.1 ఉదయం (udayam) — the same Sanskrit root, a different job than in Kannada

Last lesson’s రోజు was a genuine Persian surprise. This lesson’s word for “morning” goes the other way — straight Sanskrit, doing double duty in a way its Kannada cousin doesn’t.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఉదయం (udayam) — “morning” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama**: from ఉదయ (udaya, “rise, appearance”) plus Telugu’s own -ము (-mu) nominal suffix. This is Telugu’s most common, general everyday word for “morning” — but be honest: it doesn’t have the field entirely to itself. పొద్దు/పొద్దున (poddu/podduna) is genuine **Proto-Dravidian** vocabulary — cognate with Tamil **pozhudu** and Kannada **hottu** — and does real everyday work too (“పొద్దున్నే లేచాను,” “I woke up in the morning”). వేకువ (vēkuva, “dawn, early morning”) is labeled **colloquial**, not archaic or purely poetic. ఉదయం is the broadest, most general word — but not an uncontested one.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest cross-language twist. Kannada also has this **exact** Sanskrit root, ఉదయ (udaya) — but only inside its **greeting**, ಶುభೋదయ (śubhōdaya, “good morning”). Kannada’s actual everyday **noun** for “morning” is a completely unrelated **native** word, ಬೆಳగ్ಗೆ (beḷagge, “the shining”). Telugu doesn’t split the job that way: ఉదయం covers both the everyday noun AND, in శుభోదయం, the greeting root —

one word, doing what Kannada spreads across two unrelated ones. And unlike ರೋಜ (last lesson’s genuine Persian surprise for “day”), Telugu’s morning word holds no such twist — straightforwardly Sanskrit, start to finish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “udayam” — “morning,” Sanskrit tatsama, the broadest word, though poddu/podduna and vēkuva are real native alternatives too
- the cross-language twist — Kannada’s ఉదయ root only shows up in ITS greeting; Telugu uses ఉదయం for both the noun and the greeting
- the contrast with రోజ — no Persian surprise here, just straightforward Sanskrit

Before you move on

Is ఉదయం the ONLY word Telugu speakers use for “morning”? (No — it’s the broadest, most common one, but పొద్దు/పొద్దున and వేకువ, both genuinely native, do real everyday work too.) Does Kannada’s everyday morning-noun share ఉదయం’s root? (No — Kannada’s ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ is native; the shared root, udaya, shows up only inside Kannada’s GREETING, ಶುಭೋದಯ.) Does ఉదయం hold a surprise the way రోజ did? (No — straightforwardly Sanskrit throughout.)

Chapter 27

Evening

27.1 సాయంత్రం (sāyantram) — a distant cousin of French “soir”

This lesson’s word for “evening” reaches back to a PIE root you’ve technically already met — in a completely different language, on a completely different continent’s language family.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

సాయంత్రం (sāyantram) — “evening” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama**: from సాయం (sāyam, “in the evening”) plus a Sanskrit **-tana** suffix that turns time-adverbs into adjectives — the same suffix pattern behind Sanskrit **divātana** (“of the day”) and **sanātana** (“eternal, lasting”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here’s the striking part, checked directly against primary sources rather than assumed: సాయం itself traces to **Proto-Indo-European *seh₁-** (“long, lasting”) — and this is **explicitly** documented as “distantly related to **Latin sērus**” (“late”), itself confirmed independently to trace to the very same *seh₁- root (via Proto-Italic *sēros). You’ve technically already met sērus: it’s the Latin root already established in this course as the source of **French soir** and **Italian sera** — French and Italian’s own everyday “evening” words. That makes సాయంత్రం and **soir/sera** genuine distant cognates — one route through Sanskrit tatsama borrowing into Telugu, one route through centuries of Vulgar Latin erosion into French and Italian, both ultimately the same Proto-Indo-European idea of something “long, lasting” stretching into “late in the day.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sāyantram” — “evening,” sāyam + the -tana time-suffix
- the deep root — PIE *seh₁-*, “long, lasting”
- the cross-family cognate — the same root behind French *soir* and Italian *sera*, via Latin *sērus*

Before you move on

What is సాయంత్రం built from? (సాయం, “in the evening,” + a Sanskrit “-tana” time-adjective suffix.) What PIE root does సాయం trace to? (**seh₁-*, “long, lasting.”) What two Romance words are genuine distant cognates of సాయంత్రం, and through which Latin word? (**French soir and Italian sera** — both through Latin *sērus*, “late,” which traces to the same **seh₁-* root.)

Chapter 28

Afternoon

28.1 మధ్యాహ్నం — the same “noon” word, now also “afternoon”

You already know మధ్యాహ్నం means “noon” — precisely, “middle of the day.” This lesson’s honest twist: the word doesn’t stay that precise in modern use.

Why it’s said this way

మధ్యాహ్నం (**madhyāhnam**) is the exact word from Chapter 17, still literally “middle” + “day” — but a source fetched directly (not just a search summary) confirms it now covers “**the time between noon and evening**” in modern usage — a genuine widened sense, not just the precise midday instant its etymology points to. This mirrors what this course already found for Hindi’s दोपहर (clearly, well-confirmed widened from “noon” to “afternoon”) and, more thinly, for Kannada’s own మధ్యాహ్నం (a hedged, single-source impression of the same kind of stretch).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu also has అపరాహ్నం (**aparāhnam**), from the same classical **five-part Sanskrit day division** already found behind Kannada’s అపరాహ్నం — *prāta/udaya* (sunrise), *saṅgava*, *madhyāhna* (noon), *aparāhna* (“later afternoon” specifically), *sāyāhna* (evening). Be honest about the sourcing here, echoing the same hedge already applied to Kannada’s *aparāhna* in KA-C28: thin, informal evidence — a native-speaker forum discussion, general dictionary usage notes — points toward మధ్యాహ్నం win-

ning colloquially, with అపరాహ్నం staying the more formally precise term. Real, but not corpus-linguistics-grade sourcing — treat it the same cautious way KA-C28 treated its own equivalent finding, not as fully settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “madhyāhnam” — the same word from Chapter 17, “middle of the day”
- the confirmed widening — now also covers “the time between noon and evening”
- “aparāhnam” — the more precise classical word for later afternoon, staying the more formal term per thin but real evidence

Before you move on

Is మధ్యాహ్నం a new word, or the same one from Chapter 17? (**The same word** — “middle” + “day.”) Does modern usage confirm మధ్యాహ్నం covers only the exact instant of noon? (**No** — a directly- fetched source confirms it now covers “the time between noon and evening” too.) Is it confirmed whether అపరాహ్నం or widened మధ్యాహ్నం is more common today? (**Thin but real evidence** points to మధ్యాహ్నం winning colloquially, అపరాహ్నం staying formally precise — not fully settled, but not silent either.)

Chapter 29

Good Morning

29.1 శుభోదయం (śubhōdayam) — a claim worth real skepticism, not a settled fact

You already have ఉదయం. This lesson’s honest twist is about a dramatic-sounding claim — and about being skeptical of it, even though it came from a source fetched directly.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

శుభోదయం (śubhōdayam) — “**good morning**” — is built from శుభ (“good”) plus ఉదయం (already met, Chapter 26). Grammatically and etymologically, this is the straightforward, traditional Telugu “good morning.”

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the twist, and the honesty this time cuts against the source itself: one directly-fetched page describes శుభోదయం as **out of trend**, displaced by **English** “good morning,” with children taught the English phrase from **preschool**. That’s a vivid, quotable claim — but “fetched directly” doesn’t make a source authoritative. This is the **same genre** of Telugu/Kannada/Hindi-learning content blog already found **overstated** for Hindi’s सुप्रभात and Kannada’s own ಶುಭೋದಯ (a single uncredentialed listicle, no sociolinguistic methodology, no citations) — treat this claim the same skeptical way, not as settled.

Genuinely worth separating from that dramatic claim: సుప్రభాతం (suprabhātam) also exists — built on ప్రభాత (prabhāta), a **completely different** Sanskrit root from ఉదయ (udaya). This is **not** the same

root behind Kannada’s ಶುಭೋದಯ, which itself uses *udaya* — don’t conflate the two Sanskrit “morning” roots. A third option, ಪ್ರಾಧುಟಿ ವಂದನಾಲು (“morning greetings,” built on ಪ್ರಾಧು, Chapter 26’s genuine native competitor to ఉదయం), also exists but isn’t confirmed common either. నమస్కారం is the safer bet for everyday use — matching the same నమస్కార/नमस्ते pattern already found doing the real everyday work for both Kannada and Hindi.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubhōdayam” — “good morning,” śubha + udayam
- the honest twist — one low-authority source claims it’s out of trend, displaced by English; treat with real skepticism
- నమస్కారం — the safer everyday-greeting bet

Before you move on

What is శుభోదయం built from? (శుభ + ఉదయం.) Is the claim that శుభోదయం has been displaced by English a confirmed, well-sourced fact? (**No** — it comes from one low-authority content-blog source, the same genre already found overstated for Hindi/Kannada; treat it skeptically, not as settled.) Does సుప్రభాతం share ఉదయం’s root, or Kannada’s ಶುಭೋದಯ’s root? (**Neither** — its own root, ప్రభాత/prabhāta, is a genuinely different Sanskrit word.)

Chapter 30

Good Evening

30.1 శుభ సాయంత్రం (śubha sāyantram) — a claim that actually holds up on checking

Last lesson’s morning greeting rested on one dramatic, shaky source. This one is different — and the difference itself is worth noticing.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

శుభ సాయంత్రం (śubha sāyantram) — “good evening” — pairs శుభ (“good”) with సాయంత్రం (already met, Chapter 27 — the word whose PIE root, *seh₁-*, turned out to be a genuine distant cognate of Latin’s *sērus*, and so of French *soir* and Italian *sera*).

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest contrast worth drawing explicitly: last lesson’s శుభోదయం rested on **one** dramatic, low-authority source claiming it had been displaced by English entirely. This time, **two** independently fetched sources — not just search-engine summaries — **agree**: శుభ సాయంత్రం is genuinely, commonly used, in **both** formal and informal contexts, appropriate for greeting people after work or arriving at an evening gathering. Neither source flags it as archaic or displaced. This doesn’t mean these sources are beyond question — they’re still the same general genre of language-learning content that’s needed hedging elsewhere in this arc — but **being independently cross-corroborated** is a real, meaningful difference in evidence quality from a single dramatic claim, and it’s worth being just as honest about a claim holding up as

about one that doesn't. నమస్కారం, as before, remains a genuine time-independent alternative — but nothing here suggests it has **displaced** this greeting the way English reportedly displaced శుభోదయం.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha sāyantram” — “good evening,” śubha + sāyantram
- the honest contrast — this claim is cross-corroborated by two sources, unlike last lesson's single dramatic one
- నమస్కారం — a time-independent alternative, not a replacement here

Before you move on

What word does శుభ సాయంత్రం pair with, and what's that word's own striking cross-language story? (సాయంత్రం — a genuine distant PIE cognate of Latin sērus/French soir/Italian sera.) Is the “genuinely commonly used” claim for శుభ సాయంత్రం as thinly sourced as శుభోదయం's “displaced by English” claim was? (**No** — two independent sources agree here, versus one dramatic claim last lesson — a real difference in evidence quality.)

Chapter 31

Good Afternoon

31.1 శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం (śubha madhyāhnam) — good afternoon

You already know శుభ from the morning and evening greetings and మధ్యాహ్నం from the parts-of-day lessons. Put them together.

You'll want to know: శుభ + మధ్యాహ్నం

శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం (śubha madhyāhnam) means “good afternoon.” The second word originally centres on “midday” or “noon,” but you learned in Chapter 28 that modern use widens it into the stretch between noon and evening.

Telugu could instead have built the phrase on అపరాహ్నం (*aparāhnam*), the more classically precise word for later afternoon. It did not. Kannada made the same choice in ಶುభ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ (śubha madhyāhna): both languages chose the everyday “noon, widened” word from two available classical terms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha madhyāhnam” — “good afternoon,” śubha + madhyāhnam
- the word choice — built on మధ్యాహ్నం, not అపరాహ్నం, matching Kannada’s exact same choice
- Kannada ಶುభ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ — the same word-building choice

Before you move on

Is శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం built on మధ్యాహ్నం or అపరాహ్నం? (మధ్యాహ్నం — the “noon, widened” word.) Which sister language made the same choice? (Kannada, in ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ్ನ.)

31.2 శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం — register and evidence

You can now build శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం. The next question is when it sounds natural—and how strongly the available evidence answers that question.

Why it’s said this way

Two independently fetched language-learning sources confirm that శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం is a real, correctly formed greeting for **formal or workplace** use around noon and early afternoon.

Keep the claims separate, though. Talkpal explicitly ranks the greeting as **less common** in everyday conversation than morning or evening greetings. Preply independently supports its timing and formal register, but does not make that frequency comparison. So there are two sources for “real and formal,” but only one for “less common.” A second source must not be counted as evidence for a claim it never made.

Why it’s said this way

- శుభోదయం — the morning lesson found one low-authority claim of displacement by English; treat that dramatic claim skeptically.
- శుభ సాయంత్రం — two sources supported common formal and informal use.
- శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం — real and workplace-timed, with narrower support for its lower everyday frequency.

The three phrases do not need one uniform usage story. For a time-independent everyday greeting, నమస్కారం remains the safer choice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two-source claim — real, formal, and workplace-timed
- the one-source claim — less common than morning or evening
- నమస్కారం — the time-independent everyday alternative

Before you move on

Do both sources rank శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం as less common? (**No.** Both support its formal use; only Talkpal makes the frequency comparison.)
What is the safer all-day greeting? (నమస్కారం.)

The Telugu script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** క = ka, మ = ma, ర = ra. (Many wear the *talakaṭṭu*, a small check-mark hat.)
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** కా = k̄ā, కి = k̄i, కీ = k̄ī, కు = k̄u, కూ = k̄ū, కె = k̄e, కే = k̄ē, కో = k̄o, కో = k̄ō.
3. **A *virama* strips the vowel, and the bare consonant *stacks below the next* as a conjunct.** స + క → స్క (ska), న + య → న్య (nya). A dot **anusvāra** ం adds a final nasal.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

అ a · ఆ ā · ఇ i · ఈ ī · ఉ u · ఊ ū · ఎ e · ఏ ē · ఐ ai · ఒ o · ఓ ō · ఔ au.

Worth flagging

- **Aspiration is written.** క k / ఖ kh, ద d / ధ dh — the “h” is a real puff. Like Kannada (and unlike Tamil), Telugu keeps the Sanskrit aspirates and voiced stops as separate letters, because it borrowed so many Sanskrit words.
- **Round, looping forms.** Telugu and Kannada are script-sisters, shaped for palm-leaf writing; the two look far more like each other than like Tamil.

Telugu in the Dravidian family

Dravidian is a family entirely separate from Indo-European (English, Latin, Sanskrit). Telugu shares grammar and native vocabulary with Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam — but, like Kannada and unlike Tamil, it borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit. It also shows the family is not uniform: where its sisters say “no” with a word from the root *il-*, Telugu uses its own *lēdu* / *kādu*. The lessons trace, word by word, what is home-grown and what is borrowed.